

Implementation Roadmap

NorthStar Manufacturing - Invoice Approval Process Optimization

Implementation Roadmap Overview

The roadmap is designed to reduce implementation risk by stabilizing the process before automation. NorthStar should first update approval governance and reporting, then automate the standardized workflow, then decide whether Dynamics 365 or AP automation software is the right long-term platform.

30-60-90 Day Plan

Timeline	Focus	Key Deliverables
First 30 Days	Process stabilization	Updated Finance approval policy, updated approval matrix, backup approvers, standard tracker fields, status values, exception categories.
Days 31-60	Visibility and accountability	Approval SLA, weekly aging report, KPI baseline, manager communication, initial leadership review cadence.
Days 61-90	Automation preparation	Workflow requirements, routing rules, reminder rules, escalation model, test scenarios, Dynamics 365 feasibility review.

Phase 1: Stabilize and Standardize

Activity	Owner	Output
Update Finance approval policy	Finance Manager / Finance Director	Current approval policy with thresholds and ownership.
Validate approval matrix	Finance + Department Leaders	Current approver list, directors, backup approvers, and review cadence.
Standardize invoice tracker	AP / Finance	Consistent fields, statuses, aging, due dates, exception reasons, and overdue flags.
Define approval SLA	Finance Leadership	Documented approval timeline and overdue definition.
Create exception categories	AP / Finance	Standard reason codes for missing PO, missing documentation, vendor error, duplicate invoice, and unclear ownership.
Build weekly aging report	AP / Finance Analyst	Report showing pending invoices by approver, department, age, amount, and payment risk.
Establish KPI baseline	Finance Manager	30-60 day baseline for cycle time, overdue approvals, late payments, follow-ups, and exceptions.

Phase 2: Workflow Automation

Activity	Owner	Output
Document workflow requirements	Finance / AP	Confirmed process, roles, routing rules, exceptions, SLA, and reporting requirements.
Select automation approach	Finance / IT	Decision on interim workflow tool, low-code automation, or ERP configuration path.
Configure routing logic	IT / Admin	Routing by department, amount threshold, and non-PO status.

Activity	Owner	Output
Configure approval tasks	IT / Admin	Approver queue with invoice details and due date.
Configure reminders and escalations	IT / Admin	Automated notifications and escalation path.
Configure audit trail	IT / Admin	Approver, timestamp, decision, comments, rejection reason, and documentation retention.
Build dashboard reporting	IT / Finance	Operational dashboards for AP and Finance leadership.
Pilot workflow	Project Team	Validated pilot with selected department or invoice category.
Roll out workflow	Finance / IT	Standardized process across departments.

Phase 3: Long-Term Platform Decision

Activity	Owner	Output
Assess Dynamics 365 workflow capability	IT / Finance	Feasibility assessment and configuration requirements.
Identify integration needs	IT / Accounting	Integration and data flow requirements.
Evaluate AP automation software	Project Team	Comparison of capabilities, cost, controls, scalability, and reporting.
Update business case	Finance / Project Team	Quantified benefits, costs, risks, and recommendation.
Select platform	Finance Director / Leadership	Long-term solution decision.
Create implementation roadmap	Project Team	Detailed project plan for long-term platform rollout.

Testing Strategy

Test Scenario	Expected Result
Invoice under \$5,000	Routes to Department Manager.
Invoice from \$5,000-\$25,000	Routes to Director.
Invoice over \$25,000	Routes to Finance Director.
Non-PO invoice	Flagged for additional review.
Missing PO	Exception reason captured.
Missing documentation	Routed for correction.
Incorrect vendor information	Flagged before approval.
Duplicate invoice	Flagged before payment processing.
Unclear department ownership	Routed to clarification queue.
Approval not completed by SLA	Reminder is sent.
Approval remains overdue	Escalation is triggered.
Invoice approved	Moves to Accounting queue.
Invoice rejected	Rejection reason is captured.
Accounting handoff	Required documentation is present.
Audit retrieval	Approval history and documentation are available.

Training and Change Management

Audience	Training Topics
AP Analysts	Updated tracker, approval matrix, exception codes, SLA rules, escalation process, and reporting.
Department Managers	Approval expectations, due dates, approval queue, rejection reasons, and escalation rules.
Directors	Approval thresholds, escalations, dashboard visibility, and accountability expectations.
Finance Director	Dashboard review, exception trends, payment risk reporting, and governance decisions.
Accounting	Payment-ready criteria and handoff expectations.
IT / Admin	Routing rule maintenance, workflow support, dashboard support, and security/access management.
Vendors	Invoice submission standards and required information.

Key Risks and Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Managers view SLAs as punitive.	Position SLAs as vendor payment protection and process visibility, not micromanagement.
AP continues using old workarounds.	Retire duplicate trackers where possible and reinforce the standard process.
Approval matrix becomes outdated again.	Assign owner, review cadence, and change-control process.
Automation is implemented before rules are clean.	Complete Phase 1 before Phase 2 automation.
IT capacity delays workflow configuration.	Assess Dynamics and automation resource needs early.
Accounting continues receiving incomplete handoffs.	Define payment-ready criteria and test handoff requirements.
Audit requirements are added late.	Include Audit/Compliance during design and pre-launch review.

Recommended Immediate Next Steps

- Approve the phased roadmap with Finance leadership.
- Assign a Finance process owner for approval policy, matrix governance, and KPI cadence.
- Start approval matrix cleanup and confirm backup approvers.
- Standardize the invoice tracker and add SLA due date, invoice age, exception reason, and late-payment risk fields.
- Begin 30-60 day KPI baseline measurement.
- Prepare automation requirements after Phase 1 process standards are approved.